

Tournaments and Sanctioned Play for Non-Skating Officials

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Denver Roller Derby

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Agenda

1. Introduction, Goals, and Definitions
2. Being an Official
3. Sanctioned Play
4. Tournaments

Introduction

- David Reed / Stacktrace
- Denver Roller Derby
- Certified NSO Level 3
- I believe in explaining "why".
Question everything I say!
- Software engineer & ancient language enthusiast
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Intro to Tournaments and Sanctioned Play

Goals

- Help you graduate from scrimmage / local games to tournaments and high level play.
- Dispel fear around sanctioning and tournaments.
- Give you tools for understanding why we officiate the way we do.
- Let you move confidently into the next phase of your officiating career.

Definitions

- **Sanctioned:** ranked play following 100% of WFTDA rules and sanctioning procedures.
- **Regulation:** unranked play following 100% of WFTDA rules. Paperwork is not submitted to WFTDA.
 - **Home/Mixer:** Not a formal game type. Often but not always regulation; sometimes doesn't meet high standards.
- **Other:** exhibition games, abbreviated games (20 minute halves, 1 period, etc.), nonstandard rules.
 - **Scrimmage:** informal, practice-oriented games that aren't intended for the public and are usually not played to regulation standard.

Tournaments can include any type of derby game, but often focus on sanctioned play.

Part 1: Being an Official

How should we think about what we do in roller derby?

Officiating is a Team Sport

Our goal is to make roller derby **safe, fair, and fun**, in that order. We are highly skilled professionals, capable of understanding and applying complex rule sets in fast-moving play.

Some of the principles I officiate by:

- **Resilience is more important than perfection.** Errors happen. What matters is how we manage impact as a team.
- **Support each other**, but do not let your own responsibilities lapse to do so.
- **Communicate** professionally and with intention.
- **Be an example** to all derby participants of how the sport should take place.

Understanding Sources of Practice

There is no single source of truth for how to officiate roller derby. Our practices stem from multiple key documents and objectives.

- [The Rules](#)
- [WFTDA Officiating Resources](#)
- The requirements for sanctioning, including the Statsbook (coming up!)
- Direct consequences of the above
- Inertia. Processes change slowly!
- Indirect consequences of the above
- Conventions that aren't derived from the rules
- ~~Stuff some person told you at scrimmage that one time~~

Navigating Learning as an Official

"Okay, Stacktrace, but then how do I learn what's correct?"

- "Be curious, not judgmental". **Ask why.**
- Internalize the Rules and Procedures, but also the *principles* and *goals* of the rules.
 - Think about impact.
 - Think about how conventions support the goals of the rules.
 - Understand the flow of information from officials to WFTDA.
- Practice and make mistakes. See how the paperwork and other officials help you recover.

Officiating (and Derby) Are Conventional

- Conventions vary from region to region
- Officiating outside your region can be educational and surprising
- Nobody has to be wrong!
 - ... but sometimes, someone is.
- Accept and share practices with an open mind.
- Use your knowledge of the rules and the sanctioning policies as backstop.
Convention should never contradict the Rules or Officiating Procedures.

Professional Conduct

Tournaments and sanctioned games are very different environments than scrimmage.

- **You represent the officials community, the host league, and roller derby.**
- Respect the personhood of everyone around you.
- Do not consume alcohol or drugs while working or in uniform.
- Keep your phone in a pocket unless you're using it as a calculator.
- Do not use profanity or other inappropriate language while junior skaters are present, or at any time during a juniors bout. It's in the JRDA Rules. **Take it seriously.**
- Follow the WFTDA Uniform Policy and any specific guidance from the head NSO.
- When in doubt, ask your crew head or head NSO.

Professional Conduct: Favoritism

Everyone agrees that officials should not show favor to either team. Exactly what that means is not agreed upon by everyone.

Some general principles:

- No team logos on your uniform.
- Don't cheer or celebrate events on the track while you're in uniform.
 - Change out of uniform to cheer.
- If you discuss gameplay with other officials, be aware that others may be listening.

Not showing favoritism doesn't mean not having fun. You don't have to be a robot.

Officiating History and References

Every game you work goes into your officiating history. Officiating history shows the breadth and depth of your experience, and how you've grown during your career.

Most tournaments and sanctioned games require an officiating history with your application.

- [Start Officiating History](#)

Many applications also request references. Think about who your mentor is, who you work well with, and whose opinion you value. Ask them before you list them as a reference.

Part 2: Sanctioned Play

Understanding Sanctioning

All games have impact, but only sanctioned games contribute to **rankings**. Rankings are critical to teams' competitive futures.

- Playoffs and championship eligibility
- Ability to schedule games with appropriate opponents
- Entry to tournaments
- Financial impact (teams spend money on games based on expected rankings outcomes)

Sanctioned games are also important for your official's history.

- Demonstrates your ability to officiate higher-level derby.
- Used to assess fitness for tournaments.

Definition (*WFTDA Sanctioning Policy*)

A WFTDA-sanctioned game is a game played between two charter teams from different WFTDA leagues for the purpose of obtaining WFTDA Ranking game points. The game must be played according to the following policies with no deviations:

- The Rules of Flat Track Roller Derby
- WFTDA Officiating Cues, Codes, and Signals
- WFTDA Officiating Procedures for The Rules of Flat Track Roller Derby
- WFTDA Risk Management Guidelines
- WFTDA Charter Roster Policy
- WFTDA Forfeit Policy
- WFTDA Expulsion and Suspension Policy
- All games and uniform requirements listed in this document

Officiating Matters to Sanctioning

Sanction can be revoked. Officials play a key role in upholding the sanction requirements.

- ✅ Played by the rules and all required procedures.
- ✅ Paperwork correct and on time.
- ✅ No errors impacting the outcome.

Sanctioning is the ultimate line of defense: "We have to do it this way for the sanction."

This is your license to be loud about doing derby right.

What Gets Submitted for Sanction?

✓ Scores: within 24 hours. ✓ IGRF: within 48 hours. ✓ Statsbook: within 2 weeks.

The statsbook requires the Head NSO or stats crew to enter:

- IGRF, including rosters
- Paperwork for score, lineups, and penalties (SK and PLT or PT + LT)
- Official Review sheets
- Suspension/Expulsion sheets

Penalty box paperwork (PBT) is not required, but often helps the Head NSO resolve confusion elsewhere.

A Detour into Statsbooks: The IGRF

Section 2. SCORE & PENALTIES (Complete DURING or IMMEDIATELY AFTER game)									
HOME TEAM					VISITING TEAM				
Period 1	Points	10	Penalties		Period 1	Points	8	Penalties	
Period 2	Points		Penalties		Period 2	Points		Penalties	
TOTAL POINTS:		10	PENALTIES:	0	TOTAL POINTS:		8	PENALTIES:	0
The Official Score in this game required adjustment:				Reason for OS adjustment:					
Expulsion/Suspension notes:		Suspension was served by:							
Expulsion:							Suspension:	YES NO	
Expulsion:							Suspension:	YES NO	
Expulsion:							Suspension:	YES NO	

Your Head NSO is responsible for completing this sheet. **Scorekeepers** and **penalty lineup trackers** are responsible for supplying totals and counts.

(Think about the design of your paperwork and how it facilitates this need).

A Detour into Statsbooks: Star Passes

JAM	Jammer's Number	LOST	LEAD	CALL	INJ.	NI	Trip 2	Trip 3	Jam Total	Game Total	JAM	Jammer's Number	LOST	LEAD	CALL	INJ.	NI	Trip 2	Trip 3	Jam Total	Game Total
5	198								0	0	5	808		X	X			4		4	4
SP	67						4		4	4	SP*									0	4
6	12		X	X			4	2	6	10	6	35						0		0	4
7	198	X				X			0	10	7	808	X					0		0	4
SP	67						0		0	10	SP	99							4	4	8

During statsbook data entry, scorekeeping and lineup tracking paperwork **must align horizontally for the same jam**. This is why we use the notation we do for star passes.

Many paperwork mysteries start to make sense when you explore the Statsbook.

Rostering

- Rosters are part of the data submitted for sanctioning
- Only 15 rostered skaters may be on the track!
- PLTs check numbers to enforce this.

HOME TEAM			VISITING TEAM		
LEAGUE	Ceres Station		LEAGUE	MCR	
TEAM	Loca Griega		TEAM	Londres Supernovas	
COLOR	White		COLOR	Black	
# of players	Skater #	Skater Name	# of players	Skater #	Skater Name
1	4*		1	01	
2	0		2	02	
3	01		3	12	
4	110		4	23	
5	2		5	25	
6	20		6	3	
7	23		7	30	
8	257		8	3820	
9	36		9	41	
10	4		10	6	
11	42		11	616	
12	65		12	68	
13	714		13	69	
14	77*		14	7	
15	819*		15	80*	
16	84		16	9*	
17	90		17	99	
18	98		18		
19			19		
20			20		

Safety

- **Safety is always the first priority**, regardless of game type.
- Sanctioned games often have **more eyes** on safety and risk management.
- WFTDA Risk Management Guidelines *must* be followed.
- Jam timers, this is your space to shine!
 - Know the zone definitions and be aware of who's allowed where.
 - Check the EMTs every jam!
- You are empowered to take action on safety.
 - If you're the one who sees a safety situation first, **take action**.
 - If you're not confident taking action, get the Head Referee involved **immediately**.

Part 3: Tournaments

Why Tournament?

A derby tournament is a major production involving dozens of people and thousands of dollars. Tournaments can include sanctioned, regulation, and other games. They can span one to many days.

As an official, tournaments can offer opportunities:

- to meet highly skilled officials from outside your local community;
- to rack up a *lot* of games for your officiating history;
- to learn one or more roles in great depth;
- to participate in **very high quality roller derby**.

Getting Accepted

Almost all tournaments are *by application*. How do you actually get in?

- **Get the basics right.** Answer the questions on the application. Give serious, to-the-point answers. Jokes rarely land.
- **Communicate.** If tournament heads reach out to you, answer promptly. They're talking to lots of people, and failure to respond may knock you out.
- **Be willing to work multiple roles, if you can.** Narrow applications may not be accepted *just* because your one or two roles are full.
- **Help them say yes to you.**
 - **Provide an officiating history.** It's very hard for tournament heads to evaluate you if they do not know you and you don't provide a history.
 - **Provide good references.** Ask them first, and make sure they're ready to talk about you as a human and an official.

Weaker Application

Name

Diogo Harari

Applying for Roles

SK

Pronouns

any lol

Accommodations and Dietary Restrictions

bacon

Officiating History

never remember to update it sorry

References

Stronger Application

Name

Camina Drummer

Applying for Roles

JT, SK, PBT

Pronouns

They/them

Accommodations and Dietary Restrictions

Hard of hearing. Vegetarian.

Officiating History

<https://ceres.belt/camina/history>

References

Fred Johnson

What I Look For In An Application

3 or 4 out of 5 are under your control!

1. What roles have you asked to do?
2. How are you demonstrating your experience in those roles?
3. How does your experience fit within my crews?
4. What needs do you share with me, and can I accommodate them?
5. Have you shown me any red flags?

Ask for What You Need

- If you're traveling and need a number of games to make it worthwhile, say so.
- Share your dietary restrictions and accommodations you need. Be specific. Don't joke.
- Ask about housing options. Some leagues can provide housing with their members. Others reserve a hotel block for visitors.
- If you're new and need guidance, say so!
 - Experienced hands easily forget the new-official experience. Help them remember, and serve your needs. Good leaders will thank you.

Alright, You're In. Now What?

- Know your schedule.
- Plan travel, if you need to.
- Brush up on your roles.
 - Statsbook Manual!
- Ask for evaluations.

Example Schedule (Static Crew)

This is a "static-crew" schedule. You're staffed with the same Crew Head NSO and crew throughout the tournament. You'll work the same position in most or all games.

Day 1 (Sat)					
	G1 (11 AM)	G2 (1 PM)	G3 (3 PM)	G4 (5 PM)	G5 (7 PM)
Rotation	A	A	B	B	A
CHNSO	Drummer	Drummer	Roslin	Roslin	Drummer
JT	Draper	Draper	Gaeta	Zarek	Draper
PLT	Holden	Holden	Roslin	Roslin	Holden
PLT	Drummer	Drummer	Adama	Adama	Drummer
SK	Miller	Havelock	Anders	Anders	Miller
SK	Johnson	Johnson	Baltar	Baltar	Johnson
SBO	Nagata	Nagata	Tigh	Tigh	Nagata
PBM	Ashford	Ashford	Agathon	Agathon	Ashford

Fluid Crews

"Fluid crews" are also common. You might be with multiple Crew Heads and different crews, and you may work several positions throughout the tournament.

Day 1 (Sat)					
	G1 (11 AM)	G2 (1 PM)	G3 (3 PM)	G4 (5 PM)	G5 (7 PM)
CHNSO	Drummer	Adama	Gaeta	Roslin	Draper
JT	Miller	Dawes	Gaeta	Zarek	Mao
PLT	Drummer	Adama	Starbuck	Roslin	Draper
PLT	Starbuck	Johnson	Guoliang	Duala	Sanjrani
SK	Muss	Havelock	Anders	Anders	Retiko

Know Your Schedule and Resources

- When do you need to report? (*Not* first whistle!)
 - Are there crew meetings that aren't right before a game?
- When do you finish each day?
- When can you rest?
- When can you eat?
- Who is your point of contact? Crew head? Tournament head?
- Have the schedule handy. Download it on your phone, or know where the printed copy is.
- Where is the officials' lounge? Are there multiple tracks? Where is the restroom?

Taking Care of Yourself

It's important to keep yourself in good shape so you can support your crew and do your job.

- **You are allowed to ask for what you need to be successful.**
 - You're an asset to the event, not a burden.
- Feed and water yourself.
 - Many tournaments provide lunch.
 - Grab the healthy snacks.
- Know where your breaks are. Recharge your way. Leave the venue.
- Get enough sleep.

Work the Actual Derby

- You're going to be awesome.
- Remember to communicate and work as a team!
- **Bounce back from mistakes.** Your crew will remember that you fixed the problem, not that you made a mistake.

Accepting Feedback

I am never happier as an officiating leader than when my crew learns from a mistake or feedback they receive. **Resilience is more important than perfection.**

- Giving *and* receiving feedback are both hard.
- Try to hear feedback with joy: "Oh, that's a really good idea - let me try that".
- Leaders may speak to you very quickly during play. That doesn't indicate anger!
 - It's about the needs of the officiating team, not your personhood.
- Evaluate feedback critically just like any other learning.
- I want to help you grow, but I'm growing too.

Avoid and Defuse Conflict

- Conflict? **Focus on shared goals.** Invite everyone to de-personalize the conflict.
- Ask questions before you make decisions.
- Take a breath before you communicate.
- Understand that everyone starts from a different place.
- Ask your Crew Head NSO or Head Referee to help you resolve challenges.

Outcomes

- Update your game history!
- What did you learn? What officiating practices are new to you?
- If you're going for certification, evals and Overviews of Officiating Skill.
 - Ask your crew head beforehand!

Remember Why We're Here

- Grow as an official
- Enjoy your work
- Team up with lovely people
- Support the derby community
- Be an example
- Keep the sport safe, fair, and fun

Thanks for spending time with me

I hope you feel empowered to tackle new officiating challenges.

We can chat for a few minutes now, with recording **off**. These slides, and the recording, will be sent to you.

Great next resources:

- [The Rules](#)
- [WFTDA Online Learning](#)
- [WFTDA Officiating Resources](#)
- [Non-Skating Official Guides](#) (by Stacktrace and friends)